2.0 Basic Operations

After MP3s, images are perhaps the most commonly found files on PCs today—from your collection of wallpapers of beautiful women to dad's collection of photographs of temples. With the advent of digital cameras, images are of more personal interest to us—meaning less generic shots of monuments and such, and more of friends, family, and personal events—making it all the important to us to retouch them if they aren't perfect. Unfortunately, many of these images are indeed not perfect, having been shot by us amateurs under imperfect conditions. They might appear dull or unnaturally bright, they may look blurred, the *saturation* might be too much—meaning there's too much colour in the photo—and so on. Here's where we explain how to rectify such imperfections.

Even someone who's just taking his first Photoshopping steps, or even doing image editing for the first time, will be able to achieve the following with ease after going through this chapter and the workshops that follow:

- Reduce the file size of the image, measured in KB or MB. This is done by *compressing* the image.
- Change the size of the image by increasing or decreasing the resolution. The resolution is measured in terms of horizontal pixels by vertical pixels. Common dimensions are 800 x 600, 1024x768, and 1280 x 1024.
- Crop images so that only a desired portion of the image is retained.
- Change the brightness, contrast and *gamma* of the image. If a photo is taken in dull light, you can actually brighten them; most photos can be made *richer* just by moving certain sliders.
- Remove red or blue tinges using Hue/Saturation correction.

Many of the operations that will be discussed here will be immediately applicable to images you have taken from digital cameras. For example, if you set the shooting mode to Fluorescent (referring to the lighting) and take the shot in Sunlight or vice versa, you will see tinges of blue or red in the photo. Defects such as these can be easi-